And I and Silence

By Naomi Wallace

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray a character at 2 different time periods of her life. This is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments. The original script calls for 2 actresses to be cast for each role (ie YOUNG JAMIE/DEE and JAMIE/DEE)

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Jamie and Dee are teenagers when we meet them in Jamie's cell in some unidentified prison in an undisclosed (but vaguely Southern) American city in 1950.*

ACTRESS 2: *The 1950s – often looked back on today with nostalgia, especially when the slogan "Make America Great Again" is heard.*

ACTRESS 1: *But this play focuses on those who were present but invisible…in a society that was still very oppressive, segregated, and rife with inequality*

ACTRESS 2: *Young Jamie is black and Young Dee is white, so it takes courage as well as ingenuity for the uneducated and dim-witted Dee to keep sneaking over from the "white wing" in her campaign to make friends with smart and feisty Jamie.*

ACTRESS 1: *Two young lives going nowhere fast*

TOGETHER: *And I and Silence by Naomi Wallace*

(In a bare prison cell. YOUNG JAMIE is standing alone in her cell, looking out at something we can't see. YOUNG DEE enters. YOUNG JAMIE turns slowly and sees her. They say nothing for a long moment, just looking at one another.)

YOUNG JAMIE: I don't know you.

YOUNG DEE: I've seen you. Over and over. *(Beat)* I'm in cell block four.

YOUNG JAMIE: White block.

YOUNG DEE: Yeah. Trying to get here for weeks. I want . . .

YOUNG JAMIE: *(interrupts)* Knew you wanted something.

YOUNG **DEE:** -to be friends.

YOUNG JAMIE: Well I don't.

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YOUNG DEE: Few months ago, I saw old Mister Crackle the guard knock a bowl of hot chili right out of your hands. Hit the floor, splash.

YOUNG JAMIE: I picked the bowl up.

YOUNG DEE: Yep. But Mister Crackle, he knocked it out of your hands a second time. Me. I would have let it lay. Eight times he knocked that bowl outta your hands. I counted. And you picked it up eight times 'til Mister Crackle gave in. That's the kind of friend I want.

YOUNG JAMIE: I don't care what you want and I don't need a friend.

YOUNG DEE: I'll be seventeen in two months.

YOUNG JAMIE: I'm already seventeen for five months now.

YOUNG DEE: You got nine for robbery.

YOUNG JAMIE: Accessory.

YOUNG DEE: I got nine years too.

YOUNG JAMIE: Don't care.

YOUNG DEE: We could do time together. We could make something . . . Plans for when we get out. My name's Dee.

YOUNG JAMIE: Blue eyes make me cold.

YOUNG DEE: Didn't have no family other than [your brother]. He's dead. You're alone. Jamie is all alone. That's what they say.

YOUNG JAMIE: Hear me, girl. Get the hell out. *(They stare each other down)*

YOUNG DEE: I'm sorry about your brother.

YOUNG JAMIE: Marcel. His name was Marcel. He had a piece of wood in his pocket, made it look like a gun. We went into that grocery store together. Man in the store had a real gun. Shot Marcel in the neck. . . . We're not friends yet.

Weeks later (Dee shows up again in Jamie's cell during lunch break)

YOUNG JAMIE: Might never happen, you and me being friends. *(Beat)* You were in the

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hole. That's what they say. They say you don't sleep. You sit and scream at night.

YOUNG DEE: Who says I scream? I'll kick their face.

YOUNG JAMIE: I never been in the hole. Yet. But I been hit. Me and some girls once we sat up front at dinner time, at your table. Guards hit us on the back **'til** we moved. We got worms in our bowls so fat we name 'em. You and your table get porridge thats clean.

YOUNG DEE: Not my fault.

YOUNG JAMIE: Maybe it is. *(Beat)* What's it like in the hole?

YOUNG DEE: Dark. Like sleep without the hours.

YOUNG JAMIE: You shouldn't scream at night. *(YOUNG DEE and YOUNG JAMIE regard one another.)*

YOUNG JAMIE: What will we be when we get out? I can sew. Make a dress. Can you?

YOUNG DEE: A little bit. Shopkeepers? We'll make dresses. Put them in the window.

YOUNG JAMIE: You got to rent a shop. You got money stashed away?

YOUNG DEE: Nope.

YOUNG JAMIE: Stupid. Neither do I.

YOUNG DEE: Bookkeepers?

YOUNG JAMIE: You can read?

YOUNG DEE: Not much. You?

YOUNG JAMIE: *(nodding)* My Momma was a parlourmaid.

YOUNG DEE: A servant?

YOUNG JAMIE: She called herself a parlourmaid. Raised me and Marcel up on her own.

YOUNG DEE: She dead?

YOUNG JAMIE: Drowned . . . Cleaning floors. *(YOUNG DEE laughs briefly. Then realizes YOUNG JAMIE is not playing)*

YOUNG DEE: You can't drown cleaning floors.

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YOUNG JAMIE: One time I found her on the kitchen floor. One time on the porch. She had blackouts. Ever since she was a girl. She must of had one and fell with her face in the bucket. That's how they found her. Me and Marcel went to get her body where she worked. I asked for her pay. Gave us half a week, said she hadn't worked past Wednesday.

YOUNG DEE: We could be servants.

YOUNG JAMIE: She made enough to feed us. Sometimes she took me with her. I watched her work. You don't need much. . . . Two buckets. With strong handles. One for each of us.

YOUNG DEE: Rags?

YOUNG JAMIE: And soap. Lots of water. And a clean dress. You got to look professional. If you're dirty they think you can't clean. Got to be spiffy.

YOUNG DEE: Bingo. That's settled then. We'll be servants. Work the finest houses. Get paid in cash!

YOUNG JAMIE: Get leftovers!

YOUNG DEE: Get hand-me-downs!

YOUNG JAMIE: Get anything they throw away! But we'll have to practice.

YOUNG DEE: Yeah. Practice.

Weeks later (Dee shows up again in Jamie's cell during lunch break)

YOUNG JAMIE: Heard they gonna move you. You in the hole three times. One more time and they move you to maximum.

YOUNG DEE: Nobody's gonna move me.

YOUNG JAMIE: Once in the hole for coming here. One time for screaming. You can't get in trouble again. *We* got years left.

YOUNG DEE: Eight.

YOUNG JAMIE: And a half. You got to stop it, Dec. You got to act right. What you do this time?

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YOUNG DEE: Nothing, Christ.

YOUNG JAMIE: Dee.

YOUNG DEE: At breakfast there's this guard, Monkfish, we call him, on account of his smell. Well Monkfish he comes to the table and he drinks my juice. Why's he got to drink *my* juice every morning? Why not spread it around? So one mornin' I pour my juice into the girls next to *me*, then I put my cup under the table and I piss in it. Then I put the cup right there on my tray, waiting for Monkfish. He leans over me like he always does. Picks up the cup and drinks deep.

YOUNG JAMIE: Oh no, Oh no, Dee! Did he drink it?

YOUNG DEE: All the way down. Then his face turned pucker and his eyes go wide. Best moment of my life.

YOUNG JAMIE: He hit you.

YOUNG DEE: Didn't stop til I passed out. But I was floating I was so damn glad.

YOUNG JAMIE: Weeks in the hole.

YOUNG DEE: Months would have been worth it. Let's work.

YOUNG JAMIE: Sure then. Start with dusting. You'll need a rag. But you got to use it right. Because whoever's gonna hire you, they gonna watch you. They watch to see if you love your work. Now you hold your cloth *(Beat)* like a bird. You hold it and let it flitter its wings across the dust.

YOUNG DEE: Flitter.

YOUNG JAMIE: Flitter.

YOUNG DEE: You're makin' this up. . . Sorry. Go on.

YOUNG JAMIE: You want to be a servant you got to have something no other servants got. Grace. Good cheer. Style. And flitter. *(YOUNG JAMIE holds the rag out to YOUNG DEE. YOUNG DEE takes the cloth gingerly, awkwardly)*

YOUNG JAMIE: Do the book shelves. *(YOUNG DEE looks around, "sees" some imaginary*

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bookshelves and dusts them, leaning over.) Don't hunch when you dust. If you got to do the book shelves low down, curtsey as you dust. Like this. *(YOUNG JAMIE shows YOUNG DEE how to do it. YOUNG DEE tries, not very well.)*

YOUNG JAMIE: That's a bend not a curtsey. Don't ever bend. Over. *(YOUNG DEE is silent some moments, then calmly speaks.)*

YOUNG DEE: In the city. Outside our apartment. There were stairs. When I left for school, when I returned, I'd count them. *(YOUNG DEE stalls.)*

YOUNG JAMIE: *(Encouraging her)* You'd count them.

YOUNG DEE: Seventeen steps up, seventeen steps down. My mother would hide her wages. Keep something back for her and me. He'd hit her every time she did it and she did it every time. *(YOUNG DEE stalls again.)*

YOUNG JAMIE: Seventeen steps up . . .

YOUNG DEE: And seventeen steps down. One night he threw her down the stairs and she tried to stop herself falling and both her hands broke at the wrist. Snap. Snap. When she stood up, she held her arms out to me. I ran to her but her hands were just. Hanging off her wrists. She couldn't hold me. I stuck a bread knife in his side. *(After a moment)* Can we polish the silver?

YOUNG JAMIE: Sure. Vases and mirrors and candelabras.

YOUNG DEE: Can . . . del . . . a . . . bras.

YOUNG JAMIE: You'll have to know how to say it: "Ma'am, I've finished polishing the candelabras".

YOUNG DEE: I did it with a flitter, Ma'am.

YOUNG JAMIE: No, no. Silver you polish with a swick, swick. It's all in the elbow. *(laughing together)*

YOUNG DEE: Jamie. I've never been so . . . Even when I was out there.

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YOUNG JAMIE: Me either.

YOUNG DEE: In here it's like hell but all I feel now is –

YOUNG JAMIE: happy.

TRANSITION

ACTRESS 1: *Fast forward 8 ½ years. Both girls have been released from prison into a world rife with racial discord.*
ACTRESS 2: *Eager to put their housekeeping skills to work so they can earn a living, the friends apply for housekeeping jobs in the posh neighborhoods.*
ACTRESS 1: *But freedom from prison isn't exactly how they had envisioned it.*
ACTRESS 2: *Their hopes and dreams quickly crumble to dust.*
ACTRESS 1: *Finally . . . the friends stop lying to one another and admit to the humiliating cruelties that have broken their spirits and eaten away at their souls.*

(The present. In a small room, JAMIE and DEE are facing one another, poised, serious. Their room is made up of a minimum of furniture.)

DEE: You going to congratulate me?

JAMIE: Why? Oh, you got the job?

DEE: Yep. I got it. Seven others waiting outside for hours, soaked to the bone. But she chose me. She asked me what hours. I said

JAMIE: Any.

DEE: Yep. Asked me about silver. I said *(Imitates the voice):* "I live to polish, Ma' am. Gives me a powerful sense of

JAMIE: achievement." You start tomorrow?

DEE: Seven A M. Your day?

JAMIE: Washed the curtains. Seven rooms. Pile reached the ceiling. She gave me lunch to eat. Leek soup. Delicious. With celery and onions. And a piece of bread. *(JAMIE takes the bread from her pocket.)* I brought you the bread.

DEE: You have it.

JAMIE: I saved it for you. You didn't eat today.

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DEE: Not hungry . . . *(long pause as the "fake" happiness dies out completely)* We were happy when we were inside. Sometimes.

JAMIE: When we were together.

DEE: Here, we can't go out together. We can't sit together. We can't walk together anymore. Folks on the street see us together, everyone thinks you're my maid. Me, have a maid? How could I ever afford a maid? So we tell [them] the truth: that we're both servants. That we're friends. What do we get then? An orange crush bottle flying through the air. Then another 'cross my back. Guts from the butcher in your hair. Doors slamming behind us-

JAMIE: *(Interrupts)* Quit your whinin'. Guts in my hair is nothing. Bottle 'cross my back is nothing. I walk the street alone to work I never know what's flying through the air. Piss pot from the second floor. Dog shit. People cursin' me, white people, your people, stick out a leg and trip me.

DEE: They're not my people.

JAMIE: But when you walk to work you okay, Dee. You okay. It's only when you walk with me you in trouble.

DEE: I wish I could kill people and get away with it. *(JAMIE just shakes her head in exasperation.)* When we were inside at least our bellies were full. We got to see each other and we weren't hungry.

JAMIE: We got soup for dinner.

DEE: No we don't. Stop lying. We haven't had soup for three days. There's no money. We've got a couple more weeks here then they'll kick us out.

JAMIE: Then what are we going to do?

DEE: Nothing. Let's do nothing. Both of us. *(Beat)* Ever again.

JAMIE: What do you mean?

DEE: I can't go out there anymore. Not without you. I can't do it. You can't either.

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We should. Quit. Just quit. *(JAMIE takes this in some moments, in silence.)*

JAMIE: I want to live.

DEE: Like this? Like this? You want to live like this?

JAMIE: *(Angry)* You should be ashamed.

DEE: There's no place for us. The streets don't want us.

JAMIE: That'll change.

DEE: Bullshit.

JAMIE: So is what you're thinkin'.

DEE: A place where there's no cold 'cause winter forgot what cold was. Where there's no being hungry. That world is ours.

JAMIE: *(Beat)* You think you're the only one? I can't get quiet in my head. Nothin' in my skull but loose change, rattlin', rattlin' and it don't stop.

DEE: *(Gets a butcher knife from the kitchen area then whispers)* Yeah, but I'm gonna stop, Jamie. I'm gonna stop. Are you with me? *(Dee kneels. JAMIE comes to kneel beside DEE. The women are both calm, as though at the center of a storm.)*

DEE: *(hands knife to Jamie)* Do me first, Jamie. 'Cause I'm a coward. I might change my mind.

JAMIE: You're not a coward. *(JAMIE abruptly stabs DEE in the stomach. DEE doubles over, holding her stomach)* If this is what it is. Here with you. Then I don't mind. *(JAMIE takes DEE's hand and puts the knife in it but holds onto DEE's hand.)*

DEE: *(Whispers to her)* Jamie. *(JAMIE, with DEE helping, pushes the knife into her own stomach.)*

JAMIE: *(Almost surprised)* It hurts.

DEE: I'm happy, Jamie. *(crying)*

JAMIE: So am I. *(beat)* Hush. I hear it . . . it's coming for us. Be quiet. It's all right now.

(Blackout)

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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